

Water Usage in AI is actually a problem

Posted by u/Revolutionary-Ebb868 • • 0 points • 22 comments

TLDR: AI water consumption is actually a problem for many settlements situated near data centres, (but probably not large scale across a country).

AI consumption is a frequent cause of debate on this subreddit so I wanted to add my two cents based on research I found online.

Datacentres across the US used 449 million gallons of water a year in 2019, which while much lower than industries such as agriculture is still hugely significant especially since the extremely significant rises due to AI. Most data centres use liquid cooling that relies on water, about 80% of this is evaporated and the rest is discharged to municipal wastewater facilities. In many areas this is entirely expendable and not a problem, but for many towns and villages this can impact their water supply, especially during times of drought when water is already scarce.

This means that AI data centres can in some cases take water away from consumers. Two commonly cited arguments against this are that there is an excess of water and that it can be reused, both of these are misleading as only about 1% of the water on earth is accessible freshwater and the water used by AI data centres can't be immediately reused as it has evaporated or needs to be repurified.

However, it is worth noting that overall there is plenty of water it is mostly a matter of working out how to distribute it. Notably communities such as the cited case study below in Georgia have struggled due to new AI data centres making it a risk worth considering.

In conclusion, datacentres use of AI is something that should be considered when making datacentres and has real risks, but is not a big enough factor for stopping all AI datacentre construction.

Disclaimer: I have no qualifications in this are, this is just a personal opinion from researching various sources some of which are cited below.

Sources:

<https://www.eesi.org/articles/view/data-centers-and-water-consumption>

<https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/cy8gy7lv448o>

[<https://www.bloomberg.com/graphics/2025-ai-impacts-data-centers-water-data/?embedded-checkout=true>]
(<https://www.bloomberg.com/graphics/2025-ai-impacts-data-centers-water-data/?embedded-checkout=true>)

Comments

u/Aware_Career6145 • 1 points • 2025-12-09 07:27 UTC

Did noone read the post

Everyone is just saying

"Do you eat food?"

"Social media uses way more water"

"Your phone was made using raw materials that need water to be manufactured"

It says it right there

"For many settlements situated near AI databases but probably not large scale across the country"

u/No_Fortune_3787 • 3 points • 2025-11-20 02:47 UTC

Says the guy from his computer and/or cell phone made from rare metals. Using his network's server, with Reddit's server. blah blah blah go be amish.

u/jurkiniuuuuuuuus • -3 points • 2025-11-19 23:28 UTC

A lovely take, gets shat on. What a subreddit we are livin in.

Props to you OP for putting in the effort.

u/jiir0 • 7 points • 2025-11-19 23:28 UTC

How much water is used to keep Instagram running?

u/CarelessTourist4671 • 4 points • 2025-11-19 23:07 UTC

post this on reddit its like to eat meal into a vegan party

u/Think_Pop_5151 • 9 points • 2025-11-19 23:04 UTC

Do you eat meat btw?

u/Candid-Station-1235 • 9 points • 2025-11-19 23:01 UTC

seems more like a corrupt/broken local approvals process more than an ai problem. but hey you cope however you need to just don't be surprise when people abandon you for being a dishonest fool

u/Toast-mcFrenchfries • 1 points • 2025-11-20 11:57 UTC

.....what

u/Candid-Station-1235 • 1 points • 2025-11-20 11:59 UTC

what are you having problems with skippy?

u/Toast-mcFrenchfries • 1 points • 2025-11-20 12:09 UTC

Your response swings from government corruption to OP's corruption very strongly and i am not sure exactly why

u/Candid-Station-1235 • 1 points • 2025-11-20 12:11 UTC

no it doesn't, you need to work on your reading.

u/Asleep_Stage_451 • 9 points • 2025-11-19 22:55 UTC

What percentage of data center usage is specifically for AI?

OP? What say you?

u/Clankerbot9000 • 4 points • 2025-11-19 22:54 UTC

"AI uses water!!1"

Bro, you're typing that while eating a Big Mac that required 600 gallons of water to exist.

A Big Mac.

Six. Hundred. Gallons.

AI inference?

Roughly the equivalent of a couple cups of coffee worth of water per session, averaged over a data center.

Meanwhile:

- A pound of beef = 1,800 gallons
- One T-shirt = 700 gallons
- A pair of jeans = 2,000 gallons
- Your smartphone = 3,000 gallons

Agriculture dumps orders of magnitude more water than the entire tech sector, but somehow your burger-powered fingers think ChatGPT is the threat to the water supply.

AI "water usage crisis" is basically people discovering that computers exist in the real world and need cooling.

If you're really worried about water, great —

step 1: put down the Big Mac

step 2: stop pretending your GPU query is the problem

u/Toast-mcFrenchfries • 1 points • 2025-11-20 12:00 UTC

i appreciate the stray '1' among the exclamation marks as that is a thing i use myself to express sarcasm and you simply cannot do that by accident

u/jsand2 • 6 points • 2025-11-19 23:43 UTC

Lets not forget about their reddit usage. It eats up about the same amount as if they used AI!

And them crying about AI on reddit, the #1 place AI learns from is the best!

u/RightHabit • 1 points • 2025-11-19 23:32 UTC

I have to correct some mistakes here.

Over 90% water from beef is actually from green water. ([Source](https://ksubci.org/2020/11/16/does-beef-production-really-use-that-much-

water/#:~:text=Over%2090%25%20of%20the%20water%20footprint%20for,and%2055%20gallons%20per%20pound%20for%20poultry))

"Green water is the water available in the soil for plants and soil microorganisms. It is the water absorbed by roots, used by plants, and released back to the atmosphere through the process of transpiration. Green water can also leave the soil through evaporation or subsurface runoff, but it is considered productive only when it is used for plant transpiration. "

https://www.newswise.com/articles/what-are-blue-green-and-grey-water

In short, raising beef requires water indirectly. Cows eat grass, and grass contains a lot of water. That water in grass isn't something we can use directly.

This is different from products like T-shirts, jeans, or smartphones, which rely on blue water, water from lakes, rivers, or reservoirs, the same type of water we use for drinking and household needs.

This means that eliminating 1 pound of beef would save roughly 100–200 gallons of water. In comparison, plant-based foods like rice (~400 gallons per pound) or wheat (~200 gallons per pound) actually use blue water, so avoiding a Big Mac doesn't save as much, because rice and wheat can't drink grass water.

u/Clankerbot9000 • 2 points • 2025-11-19 23:33 UTC

Free witty, she ain't do shit

u/uporabnisko_ime • -4 points • 2025-11-19 23:16 UTC

I mean people can't just stop eating and start walking around the world naked.

u/Tiarnacru • 2 points • 2025-11-19 23:29 UTC

People can not eat this much meat. The amount of meat people eat now adays will pretty much always be a greater amount of harm than every data center.

u/uporabnisko_ime • 1 points • 2025-11-19 23:47 UTC

So because meat is a "bigger problem" we should ignore AI that is less of a problem but still a problem, until the meat problem is solved? Also I'm all for AI using up resources if it is used solely for helping humanity at solving real problems.

u/Superseaslug • 2 points • 2025-11-19 23:32 UTC

Personally I'm less concerned about what we eat and more about what we throw away

u/Tiarnacru • 2 points • 2025-11-19 23:38 UTC

None of it's great. I just hate that argument against AI. Netflix is worse on the data center side than all AI combined. Using Photoshop to generate an image uses more energy than AI. Meat production uses more energy and water than all computers combined.

If these people actually cared about the issues they claim to then AI world barely be a blip. Energy efficiency is actually a strength of it. They just have to lie to have an argument. Antis using this line that aren't also vegans are full of shit.

u/Superseaslug • 1 points • 2025-11-19 23:53 UTC

A pair of jeans is 1200 gallons of water as well.

It's all just an excuse. They refuse to acknowledge their own lifestyle costs while attacking others for theirs.

u/Significant_Milk5983 • 11 points • 2025-11-19 22:49 UTC

Sure, people building data centres - and approving the development of data centres - should perform basic due diligence